



Kinexus Systems

DIGITAL EXPORT ENGINE

IN ALLIANCE WITH COSMO INTERNATIONAL

The Export Readiness **Playbook**

How North India's manufacturers turn the 2026 FTA window into a real, repeatable export business — without the costly mistakes that sink most first-timers.

Field guide

Self-scoring assessment

Compliance checklist

2026 FTA map

A once-in-a-generation door just opened. Most won't walk through it.

India has signed more trade agreements in the last four years than in the previous two decades. For a North India manufacturer, the cost of reaching global buyers just fell dramatically — overnight.

99% of Indian exports go duty-free to the UK from 15 July 2026 (CETA)	€120B India-EU trade deal signed Jan 2026 — the largest by volume	\$100B+ India-UAE trade — doubled in 3 years under CEPA	28% of eligible exports actually claim their FTA benefit
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The UK deal alone removes tariffs of up to **18% on engineering goods & auto components**, **12% on textiles and clothing**, **8% on chemicals and pharmaceuticals**, and as much as **70% on processed foods**. The EU agreement opens a 450-million-consumer market close behind, and the UAE has become India's fastest-growing trade gateway to the Gulf, Africa and Europe.

But here is the trap nobody warns you about

Only about **28% of India's eligible exports actually claim their FTA duty benefit**. The other ~72% pay full duty — because the rules-of-origin paperwork, certification and documentation cost more than the tariff they would save. **The agreement cuts the tariff; the paperwork eats the margin**. The exporters who win are the ones who make that paperwork cheap, fast and automatic.

This playbook is built to put you in that winning minority. Inside, you'll find the five reasons export ventures fail, a readiness framework, a self-scoring assessment to find exactly where you stand, a compliance checklist, your FTA market map, and a 30-day action plan. Work through it with a pen — it's a tool, not a brochure.

Who this is for

Manufacturers and traders in engineering, wellness/Ayurveda, textiles, pharma, agro and allied sectors who are **serious about exporting** — whether you're shipping your first container or trying to make exports finally profitable and repeatable.

Five ways the export dream leaks away

Most Indian exporters don't fail at making the product or even at finding a buyer. They fail at the operational and strategic gaps in between. Here's where money, time and confidence leak out — and which discipline plugs each leak.

01 Entering the wrong market

Decisions made on guesswork, not data. Most MSMEs have no structured way to research country- and product-specific demand, competition or price points — so they chase the wrong geography.

PLUGGED BY: MARKET & ENTRY STRATEGY

02 The duty advantage leaks away

Only ~28% of eligible exports claim their FTA benefit. Without clean digital records, qualifying rules of origin and producing certificates costs more than the duty saved — so the saving is forfeited.

PLUGGED BY: DIGITAL EXECUTION + COMPLIANCE STRATEGY

03 Wrong HS code & compliance

A single wrong classification can swing landed cost by 8–12% — enough to turn a profitable order into a loss. Document discrepancies are the number-one cause of customs delays and held shipments.

PLUGGED BY: DIGITAL EXECUTION

04 Failing the buyer's audit

No buyer validation, and no traceability to survive due diligence. Serious overseas buyers don't just compare price — they audit. Shipments get rejected on quality, specs or paperwork, not cost.

PLUGGED BY: MARKET STRATEGY + DIGITAL EXECUTION

05 Operational chaos & agent dependence

Documents, logistics, payments and compliance run on spreadsheets, WhatsApp and middlemen — blocking working capital, visibility and control. Reconciliation errors trigger fines and delays.

PLUGGED BY: DIGITAL EXECUTION

The next leak is already forming

The EU's carbon border tax (CBAM), digital product rules and e-invoicing mandates are turning compliance into a **data problem**. Exporters without clean digital records will be quietly priced or locked out. Getting digital now is not optional — it's the moat.

Sources: GTRI FTA Report Card 2026; The Wire; India Law Offices; industry export-compliance reporting, 2026. Figures are indicative and vary by sector and unit.

Export readiness = strategy before setup, on a digital foundation

"Export" is not shipping a box. It's four strategic decisions, executed on an operation that can actually deliver. Get the order right and the rest compounds; get it wrong and you pay for it at the port.

PILLAR 1 · MARKET

Where is the demand?

Which country and segment actually wants your product, at what price, against which competitors. Choose with data, not a trade-fair hunch.

STRATEGY-LED

PILLAR 2 · PRODUCT

What exactly are you offering?

Positioning, specification, packaging and certification for the destination — not just "the same product we sell at home."

STRATEGY-LED

PILLAR 3 · DISTRIBUTION

How does it reach the buyer?

Direct, distributor, re-export hub or marketplace — and how you validate and win that buyer's trust.

STRATEGY-LED

PILLAR 4 · COMPLIANCE

Is it legally & structurally correct?

HS codes, rules of origin, destination regulations, documentation — airtight, and generated from your records, not retyped by hand.

EXECUTION-LED

The foundation under all four: Digital Readiness

Every pillar above quietly depends on one thing — an operation whose data you can trust. Traceability, quality records, costing and documentation are what let you qualify rules of origin, pass a buyer audit, price correctly and ship clean. **Without the digital foundation, strategy stays a slide deck.**

The principle: strategy chooses the destination and the route; digital execution builds the engine that gets you there repeatably. One without the other is why most ventures stall.

The Export Readiness Scorecard

Score each statement honestly: **0 = not really** · **1 = partly** · **2 = yes, confidently**. Total at the end and find your stage. This is the single most useful 10 minutes you'll spend before exporting.

Dimension & statement	Score (0-2)
A • Operational visibility & data	
I know yesterday's exact production output without asking anyone.	☐
My inventory, orders and dispatch live in one system I trust — not three.	☐
I can see plan-vs-actual and on-time delivery on a dashboard, not by memory.	☐
B • Quality & traceability	
I can trace any finished batch back to its raw materials in minutes.	☐
Quality checks are recorded and analysed — not just done and forgotten.	☐
I could pass an overseas buyer's audit tomorrow with documents in hand.	☐
C • Market & buyer readiness	
I have chosen my target market(s) based on demand data, not a guess.	☐
I know who my real buyers are and how to validate them before shipping.	☐
My product, packaging and positioning are adapted to the destination.	☐

Continue on the next page →

Dimension & statement	Score (0–2)
D • Compliance & documentation	
I have my IEC, AD code and GST in order, and the correct HS code confirmed before quoting.	☐
I understand the rules of origin for my target FTA and can prove them.	☐
My export documents are generated from records — consistent, not retyped.	☐
E • Finance & pricing	
I know my true landed cost and margin per SKU and per order.	☐
I have a plan for export finance, currency risk and payment security.	☐
My pricing reflects FTA duty savings I can actually capture.	☐

Your total / 30	What it means — and your fastest first move
0 – 10 • Crawl	You're running on memory and paper. First move: make the invisible visible — a digital backbone that captures production, quality and inventory with minimal disruption. Don't chase buyers yet; build the floor you'll stand on.
11 – 18 • Walk	Data exists but is siloed and not fully trusted. First move: unify it into one source of truth and lock down traceability — so you can pass an audit and claim FTA origin.
19 – 25 • Run	Connected and credible, but people still do the analysis and chase the paperwork. First move: automate documentation and costing, and start capturing the FTA benefit you're leaving on the table.
26 – 30 • Fly	Export-ready and operating well. First move: scale into new markets and layer in agentic automation — and move before competitors close the FTA gap.

Want this scored for you?

Our 2-week Export-Readiness Diagnostic turns this self-score into a measured baseline across five dimensions, with your top three bottlenecks and a prioritised roadmap. Details on the last page.

Compliance & documentation essentials

Shipments are rarely held over commercial disputes. They're held over paperwork. Use this as your pre-export checklist — and remember the golden rule: **confirm your HS code before you quote, not after the cargo arrives.**

Registrations & identity

- ☐ **Importer-Exporter Code (IEC)** from DGFT — mandatory for nearly all shipments.
- ☐ **AD Code** registered at your port, and **GST** registration in order.
- ☐ **RCMC** from the relevant Export Promotion Council where applicable.

Classification & preference (where the margin is won or lost)

- ☐ **Correct ITC-HS code** confirmed before quoting — a wrong code can swing landed cost 8-12%.
- ☐ **Rules of origin** understood for your target FTA; ability to prove originating status from supplier records.
- ☐ **Certificate of Origin** (preferential) prepared accurately — this is what unlocks the zero/low duty.

Core shipment documents (must all agree with each other)

- ☐ **Commercial Invoice + Packing List** — values, weights, descriptions identical across both.
- ☐ **Shipping Bill** (filed via ICEGATE) and **Bill of Lading / Airway Bill**.
- ☐ **Destination-specific certificates** — testing, labelling, health/safety as the buyer's country requires.

The #1 avoidable mistake

Discrepancies between the commercial invoice, packing list and shipping bill are the leading cause of customs delays. When these are generated from one digital system instead of retyped at each step, the errors — and the demurrage charges — simply disappear.

Sector	Watch especially for
Wellness / Ayurveda	The medicine-vs-food classification fork; health-claim rules (e.g. US FDA / DSHEA); GMP/ AYUSH documentation; destination labelling.
Pharma	CDSCO and Pharmexcil requirements; stringent quality validation and registration before market entry.
Agro / Food	FSSAI and APEDA; residue testing, phytosanitary certificates and traceability documentation.
Engineering	Technical standards / Quality Control Orders; OEM-grade quality records and consistent specifications.

Your 2026 FTA market map

A quick-reference view of India’s live and incoming agreements most relevant to North India manufacturers. The right market depends on your product — but the windows below are real, dated and open.

Market	The opportunity	What to get right
United Kingdom (CETA)	In force 15 July 2026 . Duty-free on ~99% of Indian tariff lines; big cuts on engineering, textiles, leather, chemicals, processed food.	Register with HMRC; Annex 3B origin declaration; certificate of origin; prove rules of origin.
European Union (FTA)	Signed Jan 2026 . Zero-duty on the large majority of India’s export value; 450M consumers; "NextGen" focus on green tech.	Rules of origin; TBT/SPS standards; the coming carbon border tax (CBAM) and digital rules.
UAE (CEPA)	Live since 2022. Trade doubled to \$100B+. The fastest gateway to the Gulf, Africa and Europe — ideal for a re-export hub.	Duty-free on ~90% of lines; certificates of origin; choosing the right free-zone / hub model.
Oman (CEPA)	Operational 2026 . A global first: structured commitments on traditional medicine (AYUSH) — a direct wellness-export opening.	AYUSH documentation; Gulf labelling and registration.
Australia (ECTA)	Live. Growing demand, niche opportunities and comparatively less competition.	Strict biosecurity / quarantine; accurate valuation.

Read this before you pick a market

An FTA only helps if you actually claim it. The duty saving lives entirely in the rules-of-origin and certificate process. Choose the market where your product has demand **and** where you can realistically meet the origin and compliance bar — then make that bar cheap to clear with clean digital records.

Two sectors where North India's edge is sharpest

Focus beats spread. These two sectors combine large export upside with a clear, winnable compliance path for North India manufacturers.

BEACHHEAD

Wellness & Natural Products

Ayurveda, nutraceuticals and herbal personal care — among the fastest-rising FTA exports, with the widest gap between global demand and Indian penetration. Oman's CEPA even opens a first-of-its-kind AYUSH lane.

Key codes: Ayurvedic medicaments 3004.90 (retail) / 3003.90 (bulk); nutraceutical supplements 2106.90.99; essential oils 3301; herbal cosmetics 3304/3305.

Win on: the medicine-vs-food classification call, GMP/AYUSH docs, health-claim compliance, destination labelling.

PROVEN ENGINE

Engineering & Auto Ancillaries

India's largest export category, and the fastest path to a visible win — the UK deal alone removes up to 18% duty on engineering goods and auto components from day one.

Clusters: Mohali, Derabassi, Ludhiana and the wider North India belt.

Win on: JIT scheduling, SPC quality, OEM-grade traceability and delivery dashboards that clear UK/EU buyer standards from the first shipment.

Your next 30 days

- ☐ **Week 1** — Complete the scorecard. Confirm your stage and your single highest-value first move.
- ☐ **Week 1** — Verify (or obtain) IEC, AD code and GST. Lock down the correct HS code for your lead product.
- ☐ **Week 2** — Shortlist one target market on demand data; sanity-check rules of origin and the duty you'd actually capture.
- ☐ **Week 3** — Map how production, quality and dispatch data flow today — and where the paperwork breaks.
- ☐ **Week 4** — Fix the biggest leak first. Put one digital record in place that a buyer could audit.



Kinexus × Cosmo International

ONE ECOSYSTEM – STRATEGY + EXECUTION

You don't need a vendor. You need an **export engine**.

Two complementary forces: **Cosmo International** designs the global strategy, selects the markets and opens the channels. **Kinexus** builds the digital engine on your factory floor that lets you actually deliver – and claim every duty saving on the table.

COSMO INTERNATIONAL · STRATEGY & MARKETS

Market entry, buyer development & trade strategy

Which market, which product, which channel – AI-powered market validation and Dubai re-export reach, led by a 19-year EXIM specialist.

KINEXUS SYSTEMS · DIGITAL EXECUTION

The Digital Export Engine on your floor

Digitisation, traceability, compliance documentation and costing – so you pass the audit, clear customs and capture the FTA benefit.

START HERE

Readiness Diagnostic

2 weeks

Your self-score, measured and verified – with your top 3 bottlenecks and a prioritised roadmap.

FLAGSHIP

Digital Export Engine

Multi-sprint

Digitise, become export-ready, launch with Cosmo's channels, operate lean. Embedded until your team runs it.

STAY AHEAD

Export OS Partner

Ongoing

New markets and SKUs, FTA-capture and carbon/CBAM readiness, automation layered in as it proves out.

Book your Export-Readiness Diagnostic →

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Serving manufacturers across North India · In alliance with Cosmo International

This playbook is provided for general guidance and does not constitute legal, financial or customs advice. Figures are drawn from public 2026 trade reporting (GTRI, The Wire, government and industry sources) and are indicative; verify specifics for your product and market before acting.